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2026: The Year of Transition Implementation.

Remarks by Professor Nakapi Tefuarani, Chairman, PNGUMHS Technical Working Group



"Welcome, everyone!

What a significant way to commence the year gathering our

senior management, department heads, and the Transition Secretariat to align with PNGUMHS vision. As the PNGUMHS TWG Chairman noted, 2026 is the Year of Implementation.

With the PNGUMHS Bill passed and now certified, we have moved from planning to action. This year, we focus on operationalizing our new structures, establishing the Interim Council, and expanding our capacity to meet the national health workforce shortage.

As we transition from the former school of medicine and health sciences structure to a

standalone university, I urge you all to maintain the highest standards of excellence.

Backed by significant government investment, we have a unique opportunity to transform healthcare education in Papua New Guinea.

"I would like to take this opportunity to thank our key stakeholders, partners, and the dedicated staff and management of UPNG and SMHS. We also extend our gratitude to the Technical Working Group and the Secretariat for their tireless efforts throughout 2025 to realize this landmark achievement.



Special appreciation goes to the Secretary for the Department of Health, Mr. Pascoe Kase, whose

instrumental leadership shaped the legal and governance framework of the new medical university. His expertise in legal drafting and policy planning ensured that all necessary National Executive Council (NEC) submissions progressed without delay.

We also thank the Co-chairs of the High-level Project Steering Committee: Mr. Lonnie Baki, Acting Secretary for DHERST, and Mr. Konny Samuel, Secretary for the Department of National Planning and Monitoring, along with all committee members for their exceptional service. Finally, we are profoundly grateful to our respective Ministers and the Government for their unwavering support as we embark on this collaborative journey."

Let us work with shared purpose to ensure 2026 is a year of decisive progress. Thank you."

New Med Uni Structure

by Transition Secretariat Team Leader, Mr. George Gani.



We are delighted to begin this year with renewed purpose, clear direction, and the energy required to implement our transition plans. While our corporate services are now aligned with their defined roles, I want to share the strategic roadmap we have collectively mapped out. This structure serves as our blueprint as we transition into a fully standalone medical university by 2027.

The organizational framework of the new university is structured as follows:

University Council

- The governing body supported by mandated committees and a dedicated Support Secretariat Office.

Senior Executive Management

- Led by the President, supported by three Vice Presidents; 1. Vice President Clinical Education, 2. Vice President Health Sciences and Research, and 3. Vice President Policy and Corporate.

Core Pillars

- The university will operate through two primary academic faculties and one comprehensive support wing:

1. Faculty of Clinical Education

- School of Clinical Sciences
- School of Pathology
- School of Dentistry
- School of Nursing and Midwifery

2. Faculty of Health Sciences and Research

- School of Health Sciences
- School of Public Health
- School of Medical Sciences
- School of Medical Education
- School of Postgraduate Research and Collaborative Grants

3. Policy and Corporate Wing

- **Operations & Administration:** Finance, Human Resources, ICT, Policy and Planning, Project Management, Legal Office, Internal Affairs, Internal Audit, Public Relations, Assets and Property, Transport, Security, and Business Ventures.
- **Academic Support:** Student Administration, Student Support Services, and the library.

This structure is more than just a hierarchy; it is the foundation upon which we will build a world-class medical institution.

By defining these roles now, we ensure a seamless transition that prioritizes academic excellence and operational efficiency. I invite all stakeholders to join us in this transformative journey as we move steadily toward 2027. Together, we are shaping the future of medical education in Papua New Guinea.

New Fleet for Med Uni.



Implementation Phase Commences

We are kicking off the implementation year on a high note by welcoming our new short-term contract officers to the Human Resources and Finance & Administration departments. Over the next three months, their priority is to finalize the setup of the Alesco Government Payroll and the Integrated Financial Management System (IFMS). These systems form the essential administrative backbone of our new medical university, ensuring long-term transparency and operational efficiency.



HR Department Update: New Team Joins Transition.

Total of 10 new staff members joined our Human Resources team on short-term contracts. Their main job is to work with the Department of Personnel Management (DPM) to set up the Alesco Payroll System. This will make sure all staff are paid correctly under our new university structure. They will also help with hiring, organizing staff records, and creating new office policies. We welcome them to the team as they help build the foundation for our new medical university.



Finance Update: New Team Joins to help with Systems.

The Finance and Administration Department also hired eight new staff members on short-term contracts. Their main job is to set up the Integrated Financial Management System (IFMS)

with help from the Department of Finance and Treasury. This team will handle:

- Budgets and Payments
- Checking rules (Compliance)
- Money records (Accounting)

By setting up these systems now, we are making sure the university's money is managed well and ready for the future.

ICT Department Update: Old team yet reenergized.



Recent ICT transitions emphasize effective planning and procurement of critical systems, with a hard implementation deadline of August 2026. The procurement of a Micro Data Centre (MDC) provides the necessary compute and storage capacity (cloud/on-premise) for the new medical university. This infrastructure supports the student ERP, covering online registration and academic management, while integrating government-standard applications including Alesco Payroll and IFMS. The ICT staff and a lead consultant are currently engaged in intensive vendor collaboration to meet immediate project deliverables.

Academic Operations and Infrastructure Development Update

While academic support services continue to function within current UPNG operational frameworks, critical ICT infrastructure developments are progressing concurrently. These interim enhancements focus on student administration, services, the medical library, and the curriculum unit. In alignment with its strategic vision, PNGUMHS is prioritizing ICT-integrated teaching and learning to advance its commitment to a paperless institutional policy. Following extensive consultations and planning phases, the University is prepared to launch several major capital projects. Preliminary minor works are scheduled to commence in March, marking the first phase of this comprehensive infrastructure rollout.

Reflections on 2025 - 8 Months of Hectic Work.



Mr. Kase presenting on transition updates during the planning workshop.

The year 2025 was the foundational period for the Papua New Guinea University of Medicine and Health Sciences (PNGUMHS). Following years of dialogue, the official Transition Secretariat Office was established in April 2025.

The transition is governed by a High-Level Project Steering Committee, co-chaired by the Secretaries of DHERST and the Department of National Planning and Monitoring. A dedicated team of five consultants and three administrative support staff implemented the roadmap developed by the Technical Working Group. Funding for these activities is secured through the Health Sector Improvement Program (HSIP) and national planning budgets.

Key Progress Areas & Milestone Achievements

Our transition initiative has focused on several critical areas, resulting in the following achievements:

Secretariat Establishment and Consultancy

The project secretariat office has been established and is actively managing the transition. We have engaged expert consultants across key areas:

- Legal and Governance
- Human Resource Management
- Finance and Administration
- Policy and Planning
- Information Communication and Technology (ICT)

Policy and Structure Formulation

We have successfully focused on establishing the foundational framework for the new university.

- PNG UMHS policy formulation in early 2024.
- The PNG UMHS structure and budget have been approved .
- Strategic and Corporate Plans Formulation.

Legislative Milestones

- The bill for the PNG UMHS was successfully passed on the floor of Parliament on October 30, 2025, and subsequently certified as an act of parliament.
- Issuance of Certificate of Necessity (Attorney Generals Office) and Certificate of Compliance (First Legislative Council).
- A dedicated PNGUMHS Trust Account established.



UPNG VC during his visit to SMHS. Met with the transition team and management



Session with staff from Department of National Planning & Monitoring



Visit to Department of Finance



Session with staff from Department of Treasury

Highlights of Key Activities



- Department of Treasury: Guided us through the budgetary process and recurrent expenditure.
- Department of National Planning & Monitoring: Led the PIP submission awareness.
- Department of Finance: Facilitated the timely establishment of a critical Trust Account.

By embracing a bottom-up approach, our Heads of Departments (HODs) provided the vital data needed to navigate this transition. We thank all stakeholders for their feedback and commitment to securing our institutional future.

Budget Planning and Preparation Workshop

Successful hosting of the 2025 Transition Budget Workshop held at Tuhava Resort from 25th-28th June, 2025.

Tuhava Budget Planning and Preparation Workshop Program

- Budget Workshop Day 1 - SMHS Senior Management & Central Agencies Presentations
- Budget Workshop Day 2 - Budget Planning and Formulation
- Budget Workshop Day 3 - Draft Presentations - Personnel Emoluments, Goods and Services and Projects (PIP)
- Budget Workshop Day 4 - Further Consultation sessions with Central Agencies officers.



Team from Department of Planning and Monitoring listening attentively to presentations.



Mr. Larry Asigau from Department of Treasury with his presentation.

PNGUMHS Strengthens Fiscal Roadmap at 2025 Budget Workshop

We extend our sincere gratitude to the key central agencies that supported the PNGUMHS Budget Planning and Preparation Workshop from 22nd to 27th July 2025.

Their expertise was instrumental in refining our financial strategy:



Mr. Nelson from Department of Finance with his presentation.



■ Stakeholders Consultation Planning Workshop

A three-day Consultative Workshop on Strategic Planning was conducted at Tuhava Resort, Central Province from the 23rd – 25th October, 2025. The purpose of the workshop was to review the draft Papua New Guinea University of Medicine and Health Sciences (PNGUMHS) Five-Year Strategic Plan 2026 – 2030. The Workshop provided participants the opportunity to gain an update on transition activities for the new medical university. Participants at the workshop included major stakeholders from key government departments and UN Agencies, staff from Clinical Schools in Goroka, Mt Hagen, Kompiani and Kujip and staff from the School of Medicine and Health Sciences.

Activities of the workshop were spread out over three days. Day 1 was dedicated to information sharing with presentations from the Executive Dean, and Legal and Governance, Heads of Divisions (HODs) from SMHS, key speakers on medical universities and strategic planning. Day 2 involved group discussions and presentations on key strategies for incorporation into the Strategic Plan, while a wrap up of the three days' discussions and compilation of key resolutions for action was accomplished on Day 3.



DHERST Ministers Acknowledgement

The Minister acknowledged everyone and thanked them for their contributions in the development of the transition activities to establish a standalone medical university. He announced the government is supportive of this reform to address workforce stages facing the health sector. There was overwhelming support at NEC when the PNGUMHS Bill was presented. The Bill will be presented to parliament next week for approval. The minister encouraged everyone to continue the great work establish the new medical university, Papua New Guinea University of Medicine and Health Sciences.

Welcome by Executive Dean & TWG Chair, PNGUMHS Transition

The Executive Dean of the School of Medicine and Health Sciences (SMHS), Professor Nakapi Tefuarani welcomed all participants to the Strategic Planning Workshop to be held from 23rd – 25th October, 2025. Professor Tefuarani thanked the participants for their presence, experience, skills knowledge motivation, leadership, vision and guidance which would be critical to achieving the outcomes of this workshop. He further commended them for taking time off their busy schedules to attend and contribute towards the workshop. He further highlighted that this was a very important workshop to chart the way forward for the next five years for SMHS and the soon to be PNG University of Medicine and Health Sciences (PNGUMHS). The purpose of the workshop was to discuss and review the Five-Year Strategic Plan and update participants on Transition Activities for the newly established PNGUMHS.



Special Welcome by Ray Paul, High-level Project Steering Committee, PM's Department.

Mr. Ray Paul commended the SMHS for hosting this important meeting and for bringing together the relevant stakeholders and partners. He stated that there are lots of plans written and little implementation being done. He challenged SMHS and the new PNGUMHS to implement this plan as soon as it is finalized. He promised the participants the Government of PNG is behind the establishment of the new university and will give its full support.



Workshop Registration and Strategic Planning Sessions

The Transition Team successfully managed all registration and logistical requirements, ensuring a smooth start to the event. The workshop's success was driven by structured sessions where key presenters shared critical insights, directly shaping the final development of our Strategic Plan.

To ensure comprehensive coverage of our institutional mandates, participants were divided into four specialized working groups:

- **Stakeholder Engagement:** Focused on strengthening partnerships and external alignment.
- **Health Sciences & Research:** Concentrated on academic excellence and driving evidence-based health solutions.
- **Clinical Sciences & Schools:** Centered on integrating clinical practice with educational training.
- **Management & Administration:** Addressed operational efficiency, governance, and resource optimization.

This collaborative approach ensured that every facet of the institution was represented. By merging high-level agency guidance with departmental expertise, the workshop concluded with a clear, actionable framework for the PNGUMHS Strategic Plan. The dedication shown by all participants marks a significant milestone in our journey toward institutional excellence and financial self-reliance.



Stakeholders and Partners



2025 Ends with HLPSC meeting: High-level Project Steering Committee Meeting



Moments away to witness the passing of the PNGUMHS bill on the floor of National Parliament, October 30, 2025.

Pride of a Thousand Tribes

“The new heartbeat of a growing nation”



History has shown, time and again, that a nation’s greatest resource is not gold, oil, or land — it is its people. And the strength of a people depends not only on education and skill, but on health. A society cannot flourish if its citizens are unwell in body or mind.

In that truth lies the story of the School of Medicine and Health Sciences (SMHS) — and now, the promise of its transformation into the Papua New Guinea University of Medicine and Health Sciences. Papua New Guinea’s journey from colonial territory to independent nation is layered with struggle, aspiration, identity, and hope. In the 1960s, as winds of change swept across the Pacific, education became one of the most powerful instruments of national awakening.

The establishment of colleges and universities during this period was not merely academic expansion — it was a declaration: Papua New Guineans were preparing to shape their own destiny.

Yet the seeds of that declaration had been planted decades earlier. In 1933, several Papuan men were sent to Sydney to study human anatomy — a remarkable step at a time when few imagined such opportunities. By the mid-1940s, Papua New Guineans were training at the Central Medical School in Fiji, graduating with diplomas in medicine and surgery. These early pioneers planted the roots of self-reliance in healthcare.

A defining milestone arrived in 1959 with the founding of the Papuan Medical College, formally established in 1962 at Taurama, behind Port Moresby General Hospital — where SMHS still stands today. It was the first institution dedicated to training health workers in the then Territory of Papua and New Guinea.

Its mandate was bold: to train medical doctors, nurses, medical assistants, laboratory and X-ray technicians, physiotherapists, and other essential health personnel. By

1970, forty-four doctors had graduated — a modest number by global standards, yet monumental in national significance.

With the establishment of the University of Papua New Guinea in 1965, the Papuan Medical College became its Faculty of Medicine in 1971. The first MBBS graduates emerged in February 1973: four expatriates and one Papua New Guinean. That Papua New Guinean was Isi Kevau, who would later become Professor Sir Isi Kevau, the first national Professor of Medicine. His journey symbolised a profound shift in national consciousness. Papua New Guineans were no longer merely recipients of services; they were becoming leaders of their own institutions.

Independence in 1975 marked the beginning of a demanding journey toward nationhood. Geographic vastness, extraordinary cultural and linguistic diversity, and infrastructural limitations tested the young country. Yet throughout these challenges, the Faculty of Medicine — later the School of Medicine and Health Sciences — remained a steady pillar of national development.

In the 1990s, the College of Allied Health Sciences joined the University. By 2001, following restructuring, the two entities merged to form the School of Medicine and Health Sciences. These institutional transitions mirrored the nation’s own evolution: from colonial dependency to self-governance, from consolidation to maturity.

From humble beginnings, growth continued steadily. By 1989, 318 doctors had graduated. Today, more than 1,700 nationally trained doctors serve across Papua New Guinea, representing approximately two-thirds of the country's medical workforce. Thousands of nurses, laboratory scientists, pharmacists, dentists, public health practitioners, and specialists trace their training to this institution.

Its physical infrastructure may not always reflect the magnitude of its contribution. But to judge it by appearance alone would be to misunderstand its essence. Its true strength lies in its people — lecturers who persevere despite constraints, students who study with determination, and graduates who serve communities across mountains, islands, and remote valleys.

For decades, SMHS has carried immense responsibility under financial and structural pressures, sustaining one of the most geographically and culturally complex health systems in the world. Despite these realities, it has remained the backbone of the national health workforce. Now, fifty years after independence, Papua New Guinea stands at another defining moment: the transformation of SMHS into the Papua New Guinea University of Medicine and Health Sciences (PNG-UMHS). This is far more than administrative restructuring. It is a statement of national intent.

The creation of a standalone medical university reflects a maturing national vision — one that recognises health and higher education as twin pillars of sustainable development, social stability, and self-reliance. As an autonomous institution, PNG-UMHS will be better positioned to strengthen research capacity, respond to global advances in medical education, and develop solutions tailored to Papua New Guinea's unique health challenges.

Institutional autonomy enhances identity and credibility. It opens pathways to stronger partnerships with regional and international universities, development partners, and global research networks. It creates space for expanded postgraduate training, specialist development, biomedical research, and innovation in areas central to our people's wellbeing — infectious diseases, tropical medicine, maternal and child health, and public health.

Global experience shows that sustained investment in medical education transforms nations. Institutions such as India's All India Institute of Medical Sciences, Uganda's Makerere University College of Health Sciences, and

Rwanda's University of Global Health Equity have become engines of research excellence and policy innovation. Papua New Guinea now signals its readiness to chart a similar path — grounded in local realities, guided by national priorities. Yet beyond governance structures or global partnerships, the establishment of PNG-UMHS represents something deeper.

It represents hope. Hope for a new generation of health professionals who are competent, confident, and compassionate. Hope that sustained investment in health and education will strengthen national productivity, dignity, and peace. Hope that a nation of a thousand tribes can continue to unite around shared aspirations.

Health is not merely a policy sector; it is the foundation of human flourishing. Education is not merely the transfer of knowledge; it is the shaping of character, leadership, and identity.

From the pioneers sent abroad in 1933, to the founding of the Papuan Medical College, to the growth of SMHS, and now to the birth of PNG-UMHS, this story is one of steady courage. It is a story of faith through hardship, perseverance through constraint, and vision sustained across generations.

This moment is not simply institutional reform. It is a heartbeat — a pulse of progress, a rhythm of national renewal.

As Papua New Guinea moves confidently beyond its golden jubilee, may the Papua New Guinea University of Medicine and Health Sciences stand as a living symbol of who we are and who we aspire to become: a resilient, self-reliant nation, proud of its past and bold about its future.

And so, the story continues — of a nation of a thousand tribes, healed by its own hands, strengthened by its own minds, and united in purpose.



Photo taken after the opening of the multipurpose hall.